



Nintendo to make 22mn Switch units

In response to the Switch selling out due to the pandemic, Nintendo will mass produce 22 million units. <https://digit.in/may20-21>



HBO Max to launch on May 27

WarnerMedia announced that HBO Max will be launching on 27 May, with 10,000 hours of content. <https://digit.in/may20-21>

A GHOST STORY (2017)

Directed by David Lowery, *A Ghost Story*, follows the story of a recently deceased white-sheeted ghost returning to his property to take care of his grieving widowed wife. Being in denial about his death, the ghost soon finds itself unstuck and immune to time. The ghost is forced to do nothing, but watch his life and the woman he loved slip away slowly with time. This movie was shot in a cramped 1.33:1 boxy aspect ratio. This confined screen expresses how the main character, the ghost, feels trapped in time and space. During the 1 hour and 32 minutes time-frame, the movie attempts to trap the audience within the same cramped frame as the ghost and forces them to relate to it. Although the story is centred around a ghost, its primary focus is the events occurring around him. Another interesting aspect of the way this film was shot is the fact that the corners of the frame are rounded. This was done to emulate the feeling of a photograph. This makes the film look like a memory or a set of memories, that are being relived through old photographs. Other than the clever use of aspect ratio, the film also had several long takes, also known as oners, to emulate the passive flow of time in dead silence.

THE GRAND BUDAPEST HOTEL (2014)

Directed by Wes Anderson, *The Grand Budapest Hotel* follows the story of a concierge of a popular European ski resort of the same name, Gustave H. When Gustave is wrongfully framed for the murder of one of the elderly women residing at the hotel he provides sexual favours to, he seeks to prove his innocence, during which he befriends a lobby boy. The movie is a story that takes place within a story and that is wrapped within another one. *The Grand Budapest* was one of the few movies that implemented varying aspect ratios. In this case, three. These three different aspect ratios represent different time periods in each of those stories.



Changes in aspect ratios with respect to time in *The Grand Budapest Hotel*

The scenes at the beginning and the end of the movie, which is considered as present day, is shot at a 1.85:1 aspect ratio. It is the most common aspect ratio for film and is the most familiar. Although movies that are shot this way may be framed to adjust in a 16:9 aspect ratio, it will be slightly cropped at the top and bottom with black bars.

As the movie goes further back in time, the aspect ratio changes to match the most popular ratio used at that time. The aspect ratio during this time period is 2.35:1, which was the most popular aspect ratio during the 1950s and 1960s.

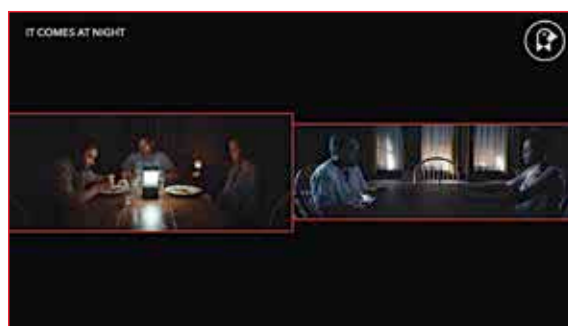
As the movie goes even further back in time, the aspect ratio changes yet again. This time, it changes to a 1.37:1 aspect ratio. The so-called boxy 'Academy Ratio'. This aspect ratio had become the studio standard in 1932.

Through these changes in aspect ratio, Wes Anderson attempts to take the audience on a journey through

time and space by emulating their usage during the early days of cinema.

IT COMES AT NIGHT (2017)

Directed by Trey Edward Shults, *It Comes At Night* is a post-apocalyptic horror flick. It tells the story of two families that were forced to live under one roof after the events, in order to keep outside evil at bay. Little did they know, true evil strikes from within. The film is shot at a 2.35:1 aspect ratio, which creates black borders at the top and bottom of the screen, giving it a widescreen look. There are some nightmare sequences in the movie. For which, an aspect ratio of 2.75:1 is reserved. The film starts off by switching between these two aspect ratios, assisting the audience in differentiating the nightmare scenes from the real ones. However, there is a visual trick taking place in the background. As the film reaches its climax, the screen subtly closes in on itself until it reaches a 3:1 ratio. This equates to watching the film through a horizontal slit. Although the change in aspect ratio is not noticeable, it is felt slowly seeping in. It is done to signify the idea that the reality within the story had gradually turned into a nightmare.



Changes in aspect ratio in *It Comes At Night*

It is debatable whether using unique aspect ratios translates to better filmmaking or not. However, those framing choices allow the audience to not just see but also feel the movie, the way the director intended and connect with it. Although it often goes unnoticed or underappreciated, aspect ratio plays a crucial role in visual storytelling. ■

Credits: Fandor